

Harvard Yard's renovated Sever Hall deserves a long look

Craftsmanship of exterior walls shines once more

By Robert Campbell
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Back at the height of the modern movement in architecture, people used to argue that you had to accept modernism, with its minimalist aesthetic, because all the old-time craftsmen had disappeared. There were no more ornamental plasterers, no artistic forgers of wrought iron, no carvers of elaborate designs in fine woods.

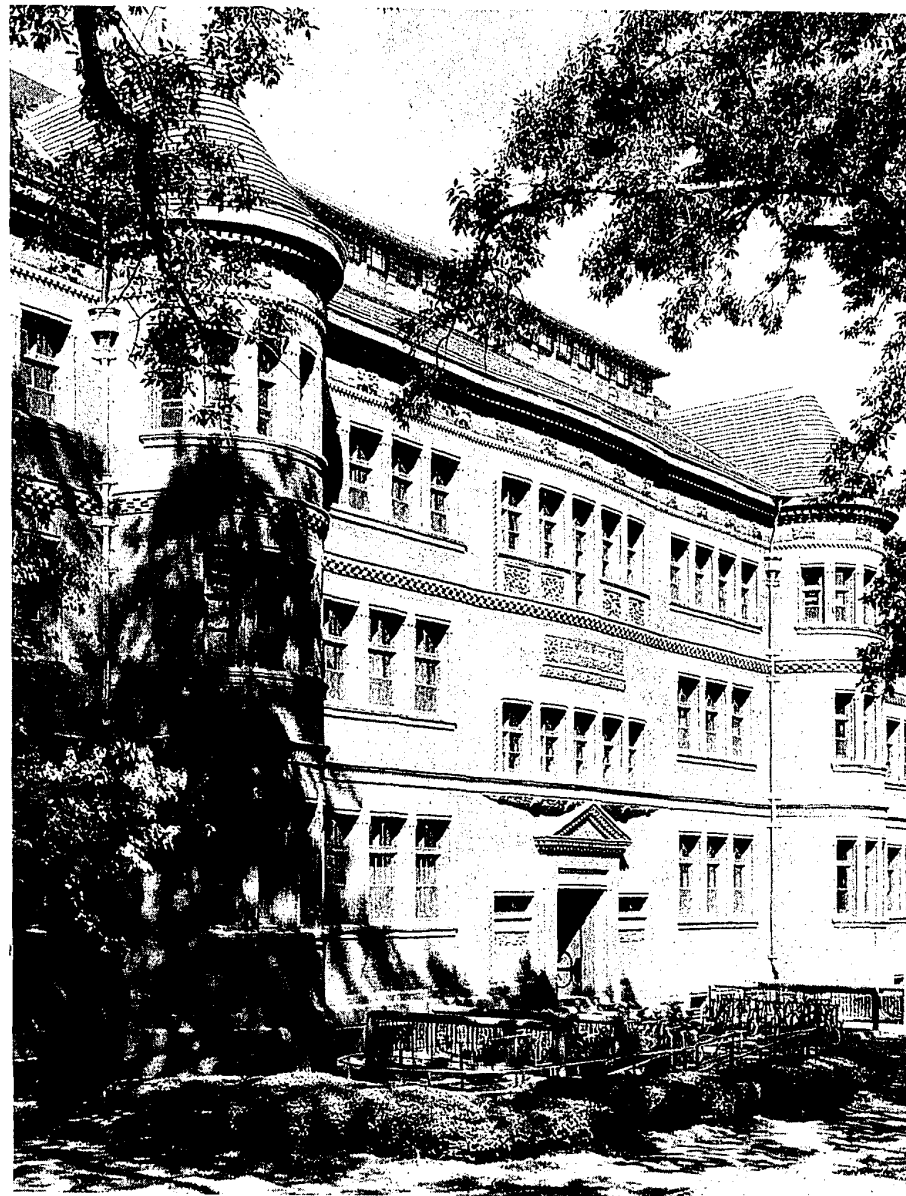
It wasn't true then, and it's less true today. A good example of how things have changed is Sever Hall, a classroom building in Harvard Yard. Sever was renovated in 1982, with results that left it looking dingy. Now it's been renovated again — at least, the exterior walls and roof have been — and it's looking fantastic. The difference is the care and craft with which the job was done.

Many readers e-mailed their astonishment, a year or so ago, when I mentioned that, in the opinion of many architects and historians, Sever Hall, which dates from 1880, is Harvard's best building, possibly even Boston's best. The architect was H. H. Richardson, the architect who first achieved fame with his Trinity Church in Copley Square.

The great British critic John Ruskin once wrote that when you go to a museum to see a painting, you should not merely look at it. You should, he said, "Watch it." When you watch something, you're expecting it to change. A good painting does change if you look long enough. You see more and more.

I suggest that people should go and watch Sever. Watch it change. The delicacy of detail is something you're not going to pick up the first time around.

I remember first seeing Sever as an undergraduate and thinking it was a dull block full of overheated



classrooms. It was a huge chunk of dark red brick — so much brick, in fact, that you vaguely felt that maybe the entire building had been carved from one enormous brick. It looked less cheerful than the other Yard buildings, most of

which sport off-white trim around doors and windows. There's no speck of white, or any other light color, on Sever. Just brick, brick, and more brick. A taste for Sever needs to grow over time.

It's easier to develop, though,

now that the brick has been cleaned and restored. It's lighter and brighter. You can see the fantastic craftsmanship. Bricks in dozens of special shapes and sizes form delicate traceries around windows, or they march horizon-



Cleaned and restored, the brick — in dozens of special shapes and sizes — is lighter and brighter.

tally as bold trim lines, or they stack into sculpted chimneys. The roof, which looks like shingles from a distance, is made of terra cotta tiles in a rich range of tones. The gentle, billowing swell of the east wall has never been so seductive.

Best of all are the decorative panels that are set into the walls. I'd always assumed that, like the roof, they were factory-cast in terra cotta or some such material. But they're not. The panels were carved directly into the brick wall itself. It's believed that the carvers were not artists but were themselves bricklayers. The work is intricate, and you have to watch a panel for a while before the imagery begins to come clear. It's heavy on animals and flowers.

Here's a challenge, readers. Find the pair of elephants that are carved into one of Sever's façades. If you can do that, you can say this is a building you've thoroughly watched. Why elephants? I have no idea. The big owl (you noticed that one, of course) is understandable as a symbol of wisdom, and the griffin isn't so unusual. But elephants? Are they symbols of Harvard's muscular athletes? (They're pretty demure for that.) Or do they disclose a bias for Republicans?

(The party's emblem had just been invented by cartoonist Thomas Nast.) Sever sheds any sense of heaviness as you engage such questions.

The architects for the renovation were Goody, Clancy of Boston, and the contractor was Shawmut Construction. Goody, Clancy also led the recent restoration of Trinity Church, and some of the same craftspeople were brought to Sever. Everything that could be saved was saved. The wood window frames, for example, are the same ones installed in 1880, now skillfully adapted to receive insulating glass.

When it had to replace something broken or deteriorated, the restoration team did it at a level of quality that appears to be fully the equal of the masterful original.

I wish I didn't have to end on low notes. Except for the attic, nothing has been done to Sever's interior, which still includes such insulating details as exposed steel fire doors in the entry hall. Nobody, either, has dealt with the ghastly entry for the handicapped. Dug down to reach a basement quarry, it looks like an abandoned quarry.

The one interior change is a mistake. The attic story was once a vast, high, wonderful space, originally used as an artists' studio. It's now been cut up into many rooms for a branch of Harvard's film-study program, plus a lot of mechanical equipment stuffed up under the high roof. The architects, Kennedy & Violich, working on a tight budget, have done everything possible to introduce a sense of space and light. It's not their fault that the result remains claustrophobic.

Harvard should have found a better purpose for the attic. Harvard should also take advantage of these innovative architects and give them something worthwhile to do.

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